



MANEESH AGHIHOTRI/www.indiatodaymagazine.com

spirit of india special ■

HOMOSEXUALS IN INDIA NO LONGER NEED TO HIDE BENEATH MASKS

woman. This is not to say that the moral policemen do not raise their heads from time to time to protest against what they see as the laxity in Indian morality. The Sri Rama Sene's intrusion into a pub in Mangalore to protect the morality of young women resulted in the nationwide Pink Chaddi campaign, which strongly expressed reactionary anxiety about tradition and the belief that women are the natural custodians of Indian values. Many an advertisement, such as the Kama Sutra campaign, has run into censorship problems over nudity. Such moral policing has in fact given rise to the proliferation of a subculture of porn, which again glaringly brings to the fore the double standards of urban morality. Upholding the views glorified by cultural nationalists, which pit the materialist and the debased West against the sanctity of Indian culture, the Indian State has banned the Internet site, Savita Bhabhi, while looking the other way when it comes to western porn. While porn featuring white women, who are viewed as natural objects of abuse, is considered acceptable by men across the country, Savita Bhabhi cannot be subjected to voyeurism. One can access this site from outside India, but the buxom bhabhi, a figure that has been traditionally sacrosanct in the imagination of Indian men, has made the site out of bounds for desi viewers.

In contrast to the voluptuous Savita Bhabhi is Kareena Kapoor's valourisation of the size zero that redefines the

literacy and revolution is still confined to the domain of high art.

At the level of popular visual culture, male bodies have been increasingly competing for attention in advertisements—the naked male torso has almost become as ubiquitous as provocatively draped female bodies. Even in popular cinema, the metrosexual male, who has set aside the image of the intense and angry young man with the heroic ideal of changing the world, holds more appeal for the urban woman. Instead, he has accepted his place beside a working

after an FIR is filed by a schoolteacher.

2006 The Christian Church and the Sangh Parivar take to the streets over the works of a student of M. S. University,

Vadodara, who paints Jesus and Durga in the nude. The Sangh Parivar vandalises the venue. The dean of the college, Shivaji Panikkar, and the student, Srilamantula Chandramohan,

are arrested.

2008 Amidst huge uproar and moral policing, Cipla launches a campaign for the over-the-counter emergency contraceptive i-pill.

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